

Reparative Game Creation: Designing For and With Psychosocial Disability

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Introduction

The relationship between psychosocial disability and videogames commonly appears in two places: games' positive or negative effect on individuals' behavior, and games' representation of mental illness.¹ In pop culture, videogames have been associated with violence, antisocial behavior, and addiction in their players. In the field of game studies, games are positioned as vessels for positive change, socialization, and self-soothing for players.² Rather than focus on the affect of players or the representation of illness in various games, this article focuses on videogame design and its possible addition to a paradigm shift that aligns media with practices of amelioration, healing, and rest. I propose a design framework called reparative game creation, a process of creating interactive media focused on healing, emotional acceptance, and accessibility for the psychosocially disabled. It is informed by disability studies, affect theory, anti-capitalist thought, and artist scholarship on research creation or critical practice. The goal of this work is to recognize the current massification of psychosocial disability, mental illness, and debility and to orient the design and use of interactive media toward healing and care, rather than toward a slow debilitation as is the current convention. Though much of game design and game studies focuses on the end product or the player experience, this article instead focuses on the process of game design, and as such it does not analyze specific games but proposes new ways of creating games informed by psychosocial disability. It is intended to be useful for game creators, artists, and designers interested in creating for and with disabilities and those wanting to rethink dominant paradigms of creation.

Gaming culture and dominant game design are in need of repair. The design of most commercial games and many independent games use a compelling and compulsive cycle of work and reward and the feeling of productivity to entice the player to play more. Most games follow a cycle of frustration and satisfaction,

1 The accessibility of videogame hardware such as controllers is also a site of discourse between games and disabilities, though it is related to physical more than psychosocial disabilities.

2 Brendan Keogh, "Games Evangelists and Naysayers," *The Conversation*, March 20, 2014, <http://theconversation.com/games-evangelists-and-naysayers-25006>.

increasing in difficulty as the game progresses. Katherine Isbister states that playing a game activates “reward-related mesolimbic neural circuits—parts of the brain associated with motivation and reward.”³ Brie Code, designer of app game *#SelfCare*, also describes gaming in terms of biochemical psychology: “Game design theory is based on an adrenaline/dopamine response to stress. Game designers aim to stress the player, and then give the player opportunities to win a challenge.”⁴ This system of play makes players feel as if they have accomplished something even if in reality all they have done is to sit in front of a screen for sixty hours and disassociate from their body and feelings. In itself, this is not necessarily “negative,” but the intense desire to feel productive is an internalization of current neoliberal capitalist culture, where one’s worth or morals are determined by productivity. Many games are designed to tap into this cultural desire, creating a cycle of work and reward are closely planned out to keep the player playing for as long as possible.⁵

Cultures surrounding gaming are often exclusionary particularly to women and people of color.⁶ In North America, white cis-gendered men are the dominant demographic of game developers. Employees at more and more studios, including mainstream and indie, have been coming forward with experiences of toxic workplaces. The games industry notoriously relies on crunch, a mode of work that demands overly long hours and weekend work, prompted often by appealing to the employees’ passion for videogames or through guilt. These crushing workplaces make game development inaccessible to many, including disabled people who are unable and/or unwilling to work in ways that actively damage their lives. Because of dominant design paradigms and exclusionary workplaces and cultures, I see a turn toward reparative game creation as a provocative and beneficial framework for exploring alternate possibilities in the videogame realm.

The following section lists the principles of reparative game creation—direct and simplified practical guides to creating games oriented toward healing and repair. These principles include how a reparative game should operate and consider the process of making reparatively as equally (if not more) important. I start with them to give a general sense of the key elements of this framework. The rest of the article lays out the foundational theories of reparative game creation, the reparative position, and healing as it relates to disability. Reparative game creation is part practical design, part analysis, and part utopian dreaming of an alternate media landscape, one that helps sustain life rather than drain it.

3 Katherine Isbister, *How Games Move Us: Emotion by Design* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2017), 3.

4 Brie Code, “About: How Do You Feel?,” *TRU LUV*, <https://web.archive.org/web/20190302171843/http://truluv.ai/about-tru-luv/> (accessed August 8, 2022).

5 See Natasha Dow Schüll, *Addiction by Design: Machine Gambling in Las Vegas* (New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 2012) for detail on how casino games are designed to keep the player playing.

6 See TreaAndrea M. Russworm and Jennifer Malkowski, *Gaming Representation: Race, Gender, and Sexuality in Video Games* (Indiana: Indiana University Press, 2017)

The Principles of Reparative Game Creation

These principles are not rules but guiding intentions for designing games with and about psychosocial disability that I have found useful in my own design process.

Repair

- Games are no more healing than any other art form.
- Games will never cure anyone. Cure is not the goal. Make work that changes the media landscape, adding to a culture oriented toward making life more livable for those with psychosocial disabilities.
- Do not only represent psychosocial disability but design for it.
- No score, no winning, no losing, no good paths, no bad paths, no one right way to play, no punishment, no reward.
- Be emotionally challenging, not mechanically challenging.
- Describing some feelings as “good” and some feelings as “bad” are judgments. They might ease classification but are not inherent or true.
- Feelings are a political resource.
- Everything is an experiment and an exploration.

Care

- Recognize not only the labor of the time spent working but also the preparation and recovery.
- Do not expect to work like a machine (consistent, always productive, not emotionally affected by mood, physical experience, environment, food, weather, past experiences, brain fog, pain, injustice, neurochemicals, microbiome, our partner’s mood, noise, etc.). We are not machines. Capitalism has set up unrealistic and unattainable work expectations. These expectations actively damage and drain us. Resist wanting and trying to live up to them.
- Know our cycles of work. Know that some are in our control, and some are out of our control.
- Rest without guilt.
- Art does not need suffering to be made.
- Affect cannot be quantified. Foster emotional self-reflection rather than aiming to funnel the players into a specific emotion.
- Do not overwork, and do not ask players to overplay.

- Be cautious—and grateful—of how much time is asked of players.
- Remind ourselves and players that there is life beyond the screen.
- Make space for self-reflection in the game: emotional choices, diary entries, mood trackers, pauses, time-outs, direct questions, and surveys.

Share

- Be vulnerable. Be radically open during the creation stage. Edit after it is already created if necessary.
- Ask others for help. There is beauty in interdependence.
- The process of making is about coming to understanding, not demonstrating understanding.
- A good game is not determined by a game one wants to play all the time. Meaningful experiences last beyond the playtime.
- Perfection does not exist. Nothing is ever perfect, only an expression of that moment in time's preferences, desires, expectations, conditions, and experiences.
- Feelings are powerful and should not be avoided, but consider how some may affect potential players. Will it make the game inaccessible to certain groups?
- Consider the audience as someone in the disabled communities, experiencing psychosocial disability and many forms of debilitation, not an audience we must explain our experiences to.

Psychosocial Disability

This article deviates from previous research on videogames and mental illness that align with medical institutions and medicalized models of health, instead coming from lived experience, process-based art, and critical disability studies. There are other terms to describe the same or similar communities, such as consumer/survivor/ex-patient (c/s/x), mental illness, neurodivergence, and mental disabilities. None of these are necessarily wrong or right; I choose the term “psychosocial disability” because it positions one’s debilitation in both the inner psychological and the outer social contexts and puts it in relation to the broader category of disability; contained within that is the field of disability studies, activism, legal status, and cultural marginalization. Although anti-psychiatry, Mad Pride, and c/s/x each have specific histories and meanings, often viewed as distinct from disability, generative concepts are produced when they are considered together, such as critiques of normality,

reconfiguring health and illness, and desiring experiences often viewed and undesirable.⁷ As such, much of the theory that is foundational to this article is affect theory and disability studies, rather than psychoanalysis, psychiatry, or psychology. Disability studies offers a way of understanding the broader context of accessibility, debility (a form of understanding how populations are worn out, decapacitated, and disenfranchised without attaching the binary of disabled/abled⁸), and culture and how they relate to mental health.

Disability scholar Lennard Davis argued that psychoanalysis is a “eugenics of the mind—creating the concepts of normal sexuality, normal function, and then contrasting them with the perverse, abnormal, pathological, and even criminal.”⁹ Psychoanalysis and psychiatry are not the only therapies and care the field of clinical psychology offers, however, they are the most common in pop-cultural understandings of mental health and most integrated into scholarship in the humanities. Still, most clinical psychologies operate on the categorization basis of “excessive” affect or unwanted behaviors. In following an affect theory– and disability studies–informed model of health and wellness, videogames are less a tool for systematically decreasing psychosocial disability, as if the goal is to overcome psychosocial disability and shed all negative feelings, but instead positions game design as a potential avenue for interactive practices that build toward creating a more livable life by providing moments of self-reflexivity, connection, bodily sensation, and acceptance.

The Reparative Position

The term “reparative” is inspired by Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick’s theorizing of paranoid and reparative positions. In previous work, I laid out the foundations for reparative game creation as I thought through my process for making the videogame *Ritual of the Moon* (2019), and how these two positions, reparative and paranoid, might not be so oppositional.¹⁰ Briefly, *Ritual of the Moon* is a twenty-eight-day long videogame that the player plays for three minutes a day, following a sparse narrative and engaging in reflective activities. It was the beginning of my thinking about combining Sedgwick’s theories with game design. Sedgwick, a preeminent queer theorist, details paranoid reading, the most common form of critique in academia, a mode of searching for and then revealing hidden violence, oppression, or wrong ideas.¹¹ The vigilance, the demand for perfection, the constant search for flaws or limitations, all prevent one from feeling other experiences or transformations—especially ones that are considered naive, such as surprise, openness, and celebration.¹² She argues that this is the most dominant form of

7 For a historical account of the relationship between mental illness and disability, see Bradley Lewis, “A Mad Fight: Psychiatry and Disability Activism,” in *The Disability Studies Reader*, 4th ed., Ed. Lennard J. Davis (New York: Routledge, 2013), 116.

8 Jasbir K. Puar, *The Right to Maim: Debility, Capacity, Disability* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2017), xv.

9 Lennard Davis, “Normality, Power, and Culture,” in *The Disability Reader*, 4th ed., Ed. Lennard J. Davis. (New York: Routledge, 2013), 8; <https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203077887>.

10 Kara Stone, “Time and Reparative Game Design: Queerness, Disability, and Affect,” *Game Studies: The International Journal of Computer Game Research* 18, no. 3 (2018); Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick, *Touching Feeling: Affect, Pedagogy, Performativity* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2003).

11 Ibid., 222.

12 Ibid.

creation in academia, and she then moves on to theorize “reparative reading.” Reparative reading would be a mode of analysis and creation that is not solely invested in pointing out more insidious forms of oppression but looks toward vulnerability, survival, affect, risks, and sustenance. Sedgwick uses words like “multiplicity, surprise, rich divergence, consolation, creativity, and love” to describe it.¹³ It does not have all the answers right away. It is vulnerable. It doesn’t default to searching for mistakes or comparisons. Opening oneself for healing and repair means opening oneself to risk, including so-called negative feelings. Being reparative can mean oscillating between good and bad affects and experiences, deeming them as not necessarily clearly divisible from each other, and approaching bad feelings as not necessarily an experience to avoid. Reparative game creation is committed to the speculative imagining of what research creation may look like when it is dedicated to survival, love, and risk.

For the purposes of this article, the reparative position or practice, reparative *reading* is being refigured to reparative *game creation*. In the context of videogames, reparative reading might at first be thought of as akin to reparative *playing*, which is certainly possible, but Sedgwick uses reading not only as the act of taking in information but also as the response to it—how academics write and talk in communication and discussion with each other. Reparative game creation focuses on the process of creation, specifically from a psychosocially disabled point of view, and ways that creators can incorporate disabled and reparative practices into process and design. Instead of a mood of suspicion, interrogation, guardedness, and desire to expose others, the reparative response takes risks in proposing, modeling, or exploring alternative modes of being and understanding—strategies very common in research creation and critical practice.¹⁴ Reparative game creation is in line with research creation that focuses on the creative process as research.

Healing

Healing, as I use it in this article, has a specific connotation in relation to disability and social justice. Disability justice activist Leah Lakshmi Piepzna-Samarasinha describes healing justice, a movement and term created by queer and trans Black, Indigenous, and people of color, in which Piepzna-Samarasinha is a major figure. She asks, “What do you think ‘healing’ is? Do you think that it means becoming as close to able-bodied as possible? Do you think it is always sad or terrible to be sick or disabled? Do you think everybody wants to be able-bodied and neurotypical, and would choose it if they could?”¹⁵ Questioning expectations of the

13 Heather Love, “Truth and Consequences: On Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading,” *Criticism* 52, no. 2 (2010): 235–41.

14 I use the phrase “research creation,” which is common in Canada. It has a similar meaning to “practice-based,” “practice-led,” “creative practice,” “practice as research,” and “arts-based research.”

15 Leah Lakshmi Piepzna-Samarasinha, *Care Work: Dreaming Disability Justice* (Vancouver: Arsenal Pulp Press, 2018), 94.

desirability of able-bodiedness and able-mindedness is integral for artists and academics interested in social activist games focused on disability to combat potential ableism. Piepzna-Samarasinha knows it is hard to get good healing, healing that is affordable, a practitioner that listens to the person's needs, and one who disavows their own expectations of what the person wants. She communicates that "most sick and disabled people I know approach healing wanting specific things—less pain, less anxiety, more flexibility—but not usually to become able-bodied."¹⁶ Healing is done to make life more livable and to have the opportunity to thrive, not to overcome or eradicate disability.

Healing can be easily dismissed—seen as not important to political futures, reserved for people with money, or an individual responsibility that is not worthy of being addressed in collective organizing. Because it is often dismissed, the burnout rate in community organizations, academia, and the game industry is incredibly high. Cara Page of the Kindred Southern Healing Justice Collective proposed that "Our movements themselves need to be healing, or there is no point to them."¹⁷ Care work and anti-ableist practices are not to be side-lined but are central to political movements—not individual practices that we do to get ready to do the "real work" again. Piepzna-Samarasinha puts it this way: "It doesn't have to be either healing or organizing: it's both . . . Healing justice is not a spa vacation where we recover from organizing and then throw ourselves back into the grind,"¹⁸ as much of the rhetoric around self-care insinuates.

For Piepzna-Samarasinha, like Ann Cvetkovich and other queer affect theorists, feelings are essential to political organizing. Many movements involve grieving and come out of a need for grief to be publicly recognized: "grief and trauma are not a distraction from the struggle."¹⁹ Healing and reparative work does not come from pushing down negative feelings and bringing up positive feelings, but from giving time and energy to both. Reparative game creation is not trying to make players feel better, to totally absolve them of anxiety, depression, mania, diagnosis, pain, and more, but to reorient media practices and play toward supporting life, sustaining energy, rejuvenating each other, and creating a life one considers worth living.

The Need for Reparative Media

While disability justice advocates are not necessarily against all uses of the medical model of mental illness, the individual nature of common psychological care limits therapy's cultural effect. Individualized therapy is not enough to tackle the world's massive

16 Ibid., 103.

17 Quoted in *ibid.*, 100.

18 Ibid., 107.

19 Ibid., 108.

amount of psychosocial disability and debilitation. Kazdin and Blase highlight the inefficiency of the individualized delivery system of talk therapy.²⁰ Although there are many techniques of therapy, such as dialectical behavioral therapy, psychoanalytic therapy, cognitive behavioral therapy, eye movement desensitization and reprocessing therapy, which are among the most popular, they almost all share the same model of delivery: administered to one person at a time or up to a small family unit. Kazdin and Blasé point out that there are not enough psychologists to address the massive population in need of care; they estimate that 25 percent of the population has at least one psychiatric disorder in a given year. In the United States, that would be approximately 75 million people.²¹ Even if the current workforce of psychologists were to double, it would have “little discernible impact given the number of individuals requiring services,” especially those who live in remote areas or do not have adequate access to health care.²² Kazdin and Blase advocate for an opening up of the delivery model from intense one-to-one sessions to less intensive but more massive scale. A treatment can look very different than what we would think of as therapy. Technology is a significant portion of this: the internet, phone calls, text messages, and apps are all cited as having the potential to deliver therapy at larger and more economical scales. Although there are many reasons to be skeptical of technological programs designed for therapy, Kazdin and Blase offer optimism for the possibilities—and necessity—of using technology to provide widespread therapeutic programs. Technology may never be a substitute for a real person, but “technology is not competing with a real person. It is directed toward the goal of reducing the burden of mental illness, and in this regard it can make a contribution to a portfolio of delivery models that is without peer.”²³ They even write that “the creativity of video games may increasingly be applied to treatment of preventive regimens and be made readily available.”²⁴ The work of Kazdin and Blase showcase how the processes of care for psychosocial disability need to be broadened and that many forms of media, communication, and organizing can be oriented toward healing.

Measuring a Reparative Experience

How can a reparative experience be measured, if at all? The majority of the reparative game creation principles are focused on the creative process, not on the player experience. This is a radically different turn from the majority of popular game design tactics, which are player-centric. Such tactics determine the success of a game’s design through player feedback: if the players’ values changed, if they understood the messaging, if they had an engaging play experience,

20 Alan E. Kazdin and Stacey L. Blasé, “Rebooting Psychotherapy Research and Practice to Reduce the Burden of Mental Illness,” *Perspectives on Psychological Science* 6, no. 1 (January 2011): 21–37.

21 *Ibid.*, 23.

22 *Ibid.*, 26.

23 *Ibid.*, 32. Kazdin and Blase define the burden of mental illness as the “personal, social, and monetary costs associated with impairment,” not the popular conception of burden as something someone else has to unwillingly care for” (21).

24 *Ibid.*, 32.

and if it enabled some “change” to take place in the player’s resulting actions. This is not to foreclose the idea of reparative play—which I believe is possible—but to problematize player-centricity and the emphasis on measurable outcomes of art.

If one were to measure a reparative experience to quantify it, study it, or use the information in next designs, what exactly would be measured? To measure emotion or affect, psychology and psychiatry use patient self-reporting or individual assessments, but often this tracks only the short term. In the field of human–computer interaction, affect has been quantified through biometrics such as heart rate and facial micro-expressions, which do not universally map onto experiences of emotion. Even if I could construct a long-term clinical psychology-style quantitative study on the effects of playing a reparative game, what markers would I look for? A person feeling “better” is not the goal, nor is a cure or eradication of bad feelings. For example, the measurement could not simply look for lessened anxiety or heightened joy as evidence of efficacy. Instead, the goal for reparative game creation is to participate in a movement of media that function as tools for care, connection, reflection, and radical acceptance of emotion. Again, I do not wish to disavow or renounce player experience as a metric or evaluative tool, and it may well become a part of reparative game creation but finding a mode of measurement while staying in line with disability studies, affect theory, and demedicalization of affect is not the goal of this article.

Others are also hesitant about the demand for quantification of the social effects of game design. Paolo Pedercini has criticized the measurement model of games-for-change, saying that “the presumption is that social change can be measured in the same way you can measure the calories burned by playing an exercise game.”²⁵ Demanding everything be quantifiable is a tool of capitalism: “If you can measure something, you can rationalize it, you can optimize it, you can sell it.” It is not that any focus on outcome is bad, but that by directing all the focus on “measurable goals we narrow our action. We favor individual change versus systemic and long-term change. We target burning calories without addressing food politics and food justice. We try to impose prepackaged behavior protocols rather than facilitating critical thought.”²⁶ The common types of change that games are designed for are small-scale and individual-focused, rather than the grander political overhaul Pedercini supports. Instead of making sure a game produces quantifiable outcomes, Pedercini argues for the liberatory potential of game design and how it can teach criticality and demystify the medium. For these reasons, reparative game creation focuses on the process of

25 Paolo Pedercini, “Making Games in a F****d Up World,” presented at Games for Change Festival (2014).

26 Ibid.

creating games rather than the games' effect on individuals. Furthermore, reparative game creation aims to strike a balance between self-change and world change. Making a game reparatively can be one transformational tool for self-reflection and healing journeys. Players may relate to the game and find it validating or transformational experiences through play. Still, a single reparative game—or a few, or ten—will not have the massive effect needed to transform the structural and systemic forces of oppression that disable and debilitate people. Reparative games call for transforming the media landscape, just one step of what needs to be a mass movement toward media that is healing, inclusive, and sustainable.

A Summary of the Reparative Game Creation Principles

I have synthesized the list of principles that began this article into five categories that summarize their themes and goals: games are not cures, design for psychosocial disability, a reparative process, no addictive cycles, and anticapitalism and speculative utopia.

Games Cannot Be Cures

Cure is a complicated issue in disability studies. For the social model of disability, there is a difference between impairment and disability; the former is the bodymind-based limitation and the latter is the effects of society. Disability studies scholar Alison Kafer summarizes it as such: "People with impairments are disabled by their environments; or, to put it differently, impairments aren't disabling, social and architectural barriers are."²⁷ Focusing on cure may address impairment but not the socially disabling culture. Cure might mean eradication of a certain way of being in the world, to make "normal," and for disability to be undesirable rather than a unique, variant part of life. Disability is so often written out of the future, as something utopia will "fix" through eradication. This idea showcases how deeply set cultural imaginings of disability as undesirable are, so the position of the social model can feel empowering. On the other hand, there has recently been more conversation around cure from scholars and activists with chronic illness and pain. While some disabled people distance themselves from being considered unhealthy, sick, or suffering, others are embracing those terms while taking seriously the social and political realities of impairment.²⁸ The suffering the unhealthy or sick disabled experience is real; some could be eliminated by social justice, but not all of it. To eradicate anxiety completely, to get rid of depression entirely, is undesirable and unrealistic. Of course, these feelings can do harm. Instead of a cure through eradication of any negative feeling, we need to find ways to live alongside them, mitigate their harm, and

27 Alison Kafer, *Feminist, Queer, Crip* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2013), 7.

28 See Susan Wendell, "Unhealthy Disabled: Treating Chronic Illnesses as Disabilities," *Hypatia* 16, no. 4 (2001): 17–33; and Johanna Hedva "Sick Woman Theory," https://johannahedva.com/SickWomanTheory_Hedva_2020.pdf.

find the political and reparative potential in them. Reparative game creation, informed by affect theory and many forms of psychotherapy, transforms these affects such as anxiety and depression into something livable at the very least, and then beyond that to being informative, community building, and politically provocative. In imagining a utopian future, let us not imagine one without psychosocial disability; let's instead imagine and work toward a future without compulsory able-bodiedness and able-mindedness, where psychosocially disabled people have control over their time, where they are seen as valuable rather than detrimental to society and productivity, and where their feelings are respected and normative expectations of emotions, care, relationships, and work are expanded and flexible.

Design for Psychosocial Disability, Not Just Represent It

The focus of reparative game creation is to consider how healing and disabled practices can be incorporated into the process of making, with an intention toward psychosocially disabled creators. A common practice in making games about marginalization and oppression is to incorporate marginalized characters at the level of character representation. Reparative game creation is about the structure of a game's design, the feelings it fosters, and the process of creating the game, not about representation of disabled and mentally ill characters. In fact, a reparative game may have no characters at all. Another common design mode for games designed for social change is to depict oppression or lived experience, such as disability, but direct the game toward audiences who do not experience that marginalization as a way of fostering empathy or social change. Reparative game creation instead is geared toward psychosocially disabled and debilitated creators designing for psychosocially disabled and debilitated audiences. Although creators might want to express our experiences with psychosocial disability or debility, it is not necessarily to inform an unfamiliar audience but instead allows us to come together, share experiences, and let each other know *I feel this way, too*. The audience is statistically quite likely to have experienced mental illness and disability.²⁹ Therefore, instead of expressing ourselves through videogames intended for nondisabled people, reparative game creation is self-expression toward community. This brings up questions related to the games design, such as is the game meant to bring about anxiety? How will that affect people with high levels of anxiety? Does it use addictive patterns? Whom does that benefit? This is not to say all games should be soothing or calming; I believe all feelings can be reparative, with reflection and intention. As creators we can try

29 In 2018, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention estimates that one in five people in the United States have a mental or physical disability. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, "CDC: 1 in 4 US Adults Live with a Disability," August 16, 2018, <https://www.cdc.gov/media/releases/2018/p0816-disability.html>.

to be conscious of what feelings the piece is bringing up, who will be feeling those feelings, what they are meant to do in the world through the imagining, designing, creating, prototyping, and play-testing stages.

The Process of Creation Itself Can Be Reparative, Not Just the Product

The process of making can be a reparative experience for the creator. This isn't specific to games; there is a long history of process-based art and art therapy. In game design, this takes away the player as the ultimate focus, which is the dominant paradigm, while not necessarily writing players out entirely. As such, it is not as player-centric as many game design heuristics and models. Games do not have to be released or widely played to be of value. Yet the process of making can feel destructive. It is the primary way making art is positioned: as our "blood, sweat, and tears," draining energy, needing suffering and self-criticism, seeming pointless, time-consuming, and even physically harmful like crunch. Reparative game creation foretells that the process can also be healing in self-reflection, feeling masterful, experimenting, articulating and communicating ideas and feelings to others, and in different forms of self-expression. The process of creation can enable understanding and refiguring the value of productivity. We need to find our own strategies that help guide us to one side rather than the other. Suffering is not a necessity of art. Psychosocial disability is not a necessity of art. Many of the reparative game creation principles are oriented toward the making process, not just the end result, in hopes of marrying the design process to the outcome.

No Addictive Cycles of Frustration and Reward

Most videogames are designed to perpetuate a cycle of frustration and momentary gratification, work and reward, and obsessive behavior to bring out addictive behavior in players. To be addicted to a videogame is not likely to be the designer's actual goal; however, game studios benefit when their players continue playing—and playing and playing. Players keep paying subscriptions, buying downloadable content, writing walkthroughs on how to 100% a game, (unpaid labor), stream (unpaid advertising), buy the sequel, and more. For most videogame designers and studios, the only reason to stop playing a game is when that game is completed, regardless of it being 1 hour or 200 hours. Within reparative game creation, growing bored is a fine affective outcome. To stop playing because the player feels satisfied is great. Rather than keep them playing, the goal is to create self-reflection on their emotional state. Cycles of frustration and reward, and increasing difficulty, are so deeply

embedded in game studies' definitions of games and the cultural consciousness around games that to design outside of it registers as not-a-game. Reparative game creation imagines what games could be if they did not have to include winning, losing, increased difficulty, score, good paths, bad paths, punishment, or reward.

Anticapitalism and Speculative Utopia

Capitalism is a major factor in mass debilitation. It determines how we make art, how we believe we should work, the materials we use, what platforms we distribute on, and which companies profit from our work. One cannot make a reparative game that requires a new console of which its production destroys the environment, uses stolen labor, or upholds abusive work expectations. A reparative game is not designed to be addictive to extract money from the player. It would not be possible for a videogame corporation like Ubisoft to make reparative games because of their carbon footprint, their capitalist business structure, and the burnout rate of their nonunionized employees. I intend reparative game creation to be useful for independent artists and small studios to inspire a paradigm shift in game design. It is utopian and speculative; not becoming stagnant in the belief that what is now will always be. Imagining and working toward utopia is not about being perfectionistic or unrealistic, but a refusal of doomed futures, settling for the status quo, and the stagnation or detriment of healing.

Conclusion

This article offers reparative game creation as a form of research creation where the process of making art is a source of coming to critical information, and the art product is a form of making research. It was not my goal to cement the ideas and principles in perpetuity; rather, the principles are intended to be ever-changing and nonprescriptive as we become mindful of what strategies work best when and for what. It resists measurement—at least measurements that reify able-minded-centricity and props up demands to erase so-called negative feelings. This article outlines what reparative game creation is and its foundational principles to give a practical framework for those interested in designing more restorative, reparative, and different games. It aims to reconfigure Sedgwick's reparative position into reparative game creation, a mode of making games that aims to promote repair, healing, and spaces for feelings not common in videogames. "Reparative" does not mean curing or becoming able-bodied or able-minded, but to support and encourage a vibrant life rather than sap and deplete it. Creating and sharing videogames that support psychosocial disability is one way to move toward a more healing and caring media landscape.